

Common Scams to Look for

Scams often target older adults because they are sometimes trusting or unfamiliar with newer technology. The good news is that knowing what to watch out for can help protect you from these scams.

Remember:

-  Stop and think before sending money to someone unfamiliar.
-  Verify as much information as possible to avoid falling into a scam.
-  Ask a trusted family member if you feel suspicious about something.

The following list provides examples of common types of scams to look out for.

1. Phone Call Scams

There are many types of phone call scams. Common examples of phone call scams include impersonator scams, debt relief and credit repair scams, business and investment scams, charity scams, extended car warranties, free trial scams, prize and lottery scams, and travel or timeshare scams.

The following table summarizes each of these scams along with a description and an example of what usually happens during each of these phone call scams.

Phone Call Scam	What Usually Happens	Example
Impersonator Scams	A scammer will attempt to impersonate an organization or someone that holds a significant role in your life. After grabbing your attention, the scammer will try to get you to tell them confidential	A scammer impersonates Bank of America and tells you that your account has been compromised. The scammer asks you to tell them your bank account information.

	information. This can include your bank account information, your social security number, or other pieces of confidential information.	
Debt Relief and Credit Repair Scams	A scammer claims to lower your credit card interest rates or your debt if you pay a starting fee. This scam is meant to get ahold of your credit card or bank account information.	A scammer calls you and says that if you participate in their program, your credit card interest rates will lower. They claim that you must pay a hundred dollar starting fee to participate.
Business and Investment Scams	These scams provide plenty of testimonials that claim that people have made tons of money following a certain program. The scammers claim that the profits will come with little effort and often suggest that they have a secret method to make money fast. Oftentimes, after investing your money with thoughts that it will grow, the scammers will take your money and disappear without any trace.	A scammer calls you to tell you to check out an app to invest money. On the app, there are plenty of testimonials claiming that people have made tons of money using the app. The scammer claims that the app will tell you about their special secret to make money.
Charity Scams	A scammer will	A scammer talks about

	pretend to be a charity. The scammer will often provide sob stories to emotionally convince you to donate money. In actuality, the money you donate does not go to a charity and instead goes to the scammer.	a person from a war torn region and talks about how the person is suffering from hunger and homelessness. The scammer also cries while describing their conditions. The scammer asks you to donate money to their “charity.”
Extended Car Warranties	A scammer presents you with your personal vehicle’s information, such as what type of car you have and when you bought it, to make them seem trustworthy. Then, the scammer says that your vehicle’s warranty is about to expire and that you must activate an important additional warranty. This scam is used to gain access to your financial information.	A scammer calls you and tells you that the warranty for the Honda Civic that you bought in 2022 has expired and that you must pay for an additional warranty. The scammer claims that if you do not invest in the additional warranty, your vehicle will be taken away by the government.
Free Trial Scams	A scammer entices you for a “free trial” of a product or service. The scammer does not tell you about what happens after the free trial ends, and you end up accumulating unexpected charges.	A scammer tells you about a set of skincare products used to minimize the appearance of wrinkles. The scammer tells you to put your credit card information for a free trial of this

		product. The scammer has actually signed you up to pay for one year's worth of the skincare products alongside the free trial.
Prize and Lottery Scams	A scammer claims that you have earned some sort of prize or lottery and explains that there are some fees that you must pay before you activate the prize. In actuality, you have not won a prize, and the scammer is attempting to gain access to your financial information.	A scammer tells you that you have won a lottery for \$5,000. The scammer explains that you must pay a tax fee before you are able to have access to your prize.
Travel or Timeshare Scams	In a travel scam, a scammer will promise low-cost vacations, but once you respond, they tell you that you must pay starting fees or taxes that end up costing more than planning a vacation yourself. In a timeshare scam, the scammer will call you and say that there are many buyers ready to purchase your timeshare. In actuality, timeshares are very difficult to resell, and the scammer will run away with your money.	You lease a condo from a timeshare and receive a call saying that they will guarantee that you will get big returns on your resale and claim that there are plenty of people waiting in line for your time share.

2. Grandparent and Family Scams

Like phone call scams, scammers often try to impersonate grandchildren or family members in order to steal personal or financial information from older adults. Grandparent and family scams can be found on social media, text message, and phone calls. These scams are particularly stressful to handle because older adults often feel the urge to act quickly to save their loved one.

Older adults often believe these scams because the scammers emulate their grandchild or family member. Scammers often find personal information by looking through social media or purchasing confidential information from cyber thieves.

Grandparent and family scams often tell the elder to keep the phone call or notification as a secret. This is a common technique that can help you realize whether the call or notification is a scam.

One way that scammers make themselves appear more real is by “spoofing” the caller ID to make it appear that it is coming from a trusted source. Scammers have also now been using artificial intelligence to create a voice that sounds like the family member or grandchild.

The best way to avoid a grandparent or family scam is to hang up the phone and directly call back your grandchild or family member using your phone line. If they do not pick up the phone, you should still not send any money or personal information and instead notify another close relative about the phone call or notification that you received.

It is important to report any grandparent or family scams that you encounter to your local police or report the scam to a scam prevention hotline.

3. Technology Support Scams

Technology support scams attempt to make you believe that there is some sort of virus or issue with your device. These scams often start with a pop-up warning on your computer. Oftentimes, the pop-ups are created to look like an antivirus company or the company that your machine is from.

Most times, the pop-up will want you to click a button that might say “scan computer” or “check for viruses.” It is important to not click any of those buttons.

If you encounter a technology support scam on the phone, the scammer will often ask you to provide remote access to your computer and claim to scan it for viruses. This is dangerous because it will provide the scammer with access to critical personal information like your passwords and bank accounts.

Other times, a scammer will say that they have found viruses in your machine and that you must pay for them to remove them. The scammer might also propose that your antivirus subscription has expired.

The best way to handle a technology support scam situation is by closing your browser and device. Afterwards, go back into your device and find the location of your antivirus. There, check for any notifications regarding if your computer has any viruses. It is important to especially have a trusted antivirus for situations like these. Having a credible ad blocker on your computer will also help prevent any malicious advertisements from reaching your device.

4. Medicare and Health Insurance Scams

Government agencies rarely call people for money or personal information. Therefore, it is crucial to be extra cautious if you answer a phone call from a government agency.

There are many instances when scammers advertise large discounts on health insurance. Scammers may also sometimes contact elders and ask them for their Medicare number, stating that they want to issue them a new Medicare card. Scammers often convey fear by stating that not providing this information may stop you from receiving Medicare benefits.

In these situations, if you feel that something seems too good to be true, always be suspicious. If you hear a request for personal information in an unsolicited call, you should put down the phone immediately. Oftentimes, the scammers will continue to keep calling you. It is important to not answer the phone again.

5. Online Shopping Scams

Every time you type into a search bar, it is important to always double-check if you have searched the right URL. There are many websites with URLs that oftentimes have just one letter of a difference and are used for online shopping scams. These fake e-commerce sites are used to sell products that look just like the products found on the real site. However, these products will not be delivered to you, and the scammers will take your money.

Outdated logos are one way to identify whether a web page is a fake e-commerce site. However, scammers are often very meticulous in creating a fake website similar to the real one. Therefore, it is important to always verify the legitimacy of a website before purchasing something or entering sensitive information.

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